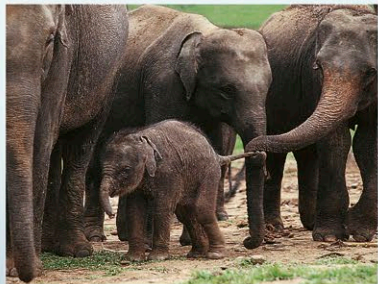


Social group

Elephants live in family groups that consist of the oldest, most experienced female (the matriarch) and other females of various ages (and their young). For protection, or when feeding in lush areas, small herds of African elephants may join together to form groups made up of several hundred individuals. African forest elephants and Asian elephants live in small family groups only. Males, however, only join the herd when a female is sexually receptive and are otherwise either solitary (older bulls) or live in bachelor groups (young bulls). Adult bull Asian elephants have annual periods of sexual excitement, called “musth” (bull African elephants have an equivalent condition, about which less is known).

PROTECTING YOUNG

Elephant calves are protected from predators and other dangers by all members of the herd, which are usually blood relatives. This Asian elephant calf is only a few weeks old and remains close to its mother. Two smaller females are close by, ready to assist the mother if necessary.



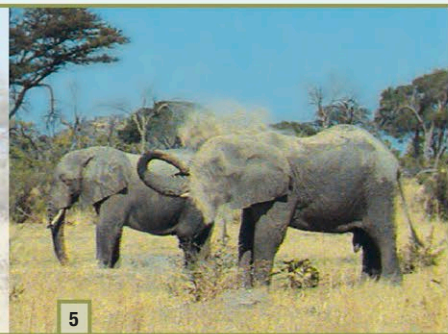
CONSERVATION

The Asian elephant is endangered due to competition with a growing human population, and its expanding need for land. The same is true of African elephants, where their original habitat of forest and savanna is becoming increasingly fragmented and farmed. African elephants also face the hazard of hunting—a traditional practice that is a source of meat, and of highly valuable ivory. During the 20th century, ivory prices soared, and commercial hunting became widespread. Elephant numbers crashed—an effect spurred on by periodic droughts. In 1989, the Kenyan authorities acted, burning a stockpile of seized ivory that sent a worldwide message. In 1990, the international sale of ivory was banned, although in the 21st century, strong demand for it remains.



LIVING TOGETHER

This is a typical African elephant family group. Communication within a herd takes many forms, including vocalizations (some of which are below the range of human hearing), touch, foot stamping, and body postures. Cooperative behavior—such as employing a system of lookouts while bathing—is common.



DEPOSITING THE DUST

The elephant blows out the dust through the trunk, depositing it on the back and head.

KEEPING THE SKIN HEALTHY

To maintain good skin condition, regular dust-baths are as important as water-baths.

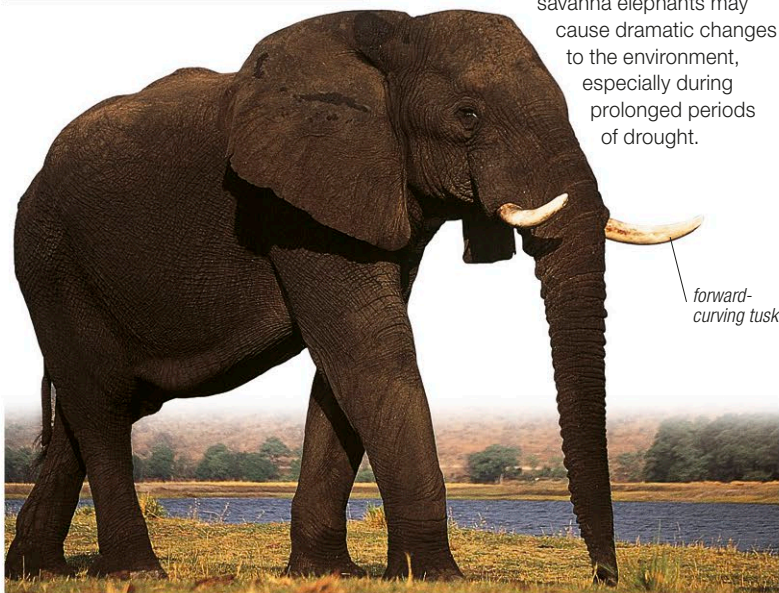
Loxodonta africana

African savanna elephant



Length 13–16 ft (4–5 m)
Tail 3¼–5 ft (1–1.5 m)
Weight 2¾–5½ tons (2.8–6 tonnes)
Social unit Group
Status Vulnerable

Location Africa



Although it is also called the African bush or savanna elephant, this species—the largest of the 3 elephant species—lives in varied habitats from desert to high rain forest. It has larger ears than the Asian elephant, a concave curve to its back, and 2 processes on the tip of the trunk rather than one (see opposite). Both male and female African savanna elephants have forward-curving tusks (incisor teeth), which are sometimes used as tools to loosen mineral-rich soil that is then eaten. Requiring substantial amounts of food and a large area in which to forage for it, a herd of African savanna elephants may cause dramatic changes to the environment, especially during prolonged periods of drought.

Loxodonta cyclotis

African forest elephant

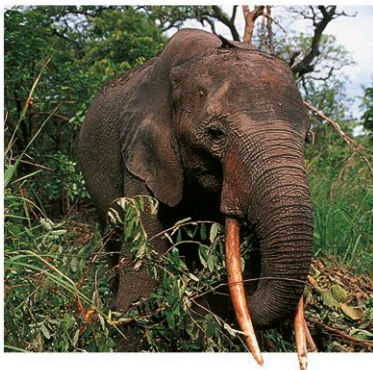


Length 9¾–13 ft (3–4 m)
Tail 3¼–5 ft (1–1.5 m)
Weight 2½–5½ tons (2.7–6 tonnes)
Social unit Group
Status Endangered

Location C. Africa



Formerly regarded as a subspecies of the African savanna elephant, this species is smaller, has darker skin, more rounded ears, and a hairier trunk. The yellow or brownish tusks are parallel and point downward, adaptations that allow the African forest elephant to move freely through dense vegetation.



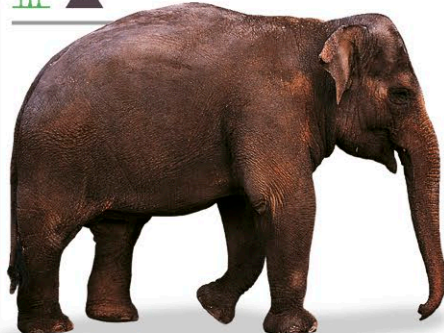
Elephas maximus

Asiatic elephant



Length Up to 11 ft (3.5 m)
Tail 4–5 ft (1.2–1.5 m)
Weight 2½–4½ tons (2.7–4.2 tonnes)
Social unit Group
Status Endangered

Location S. and S.E. Asia



Asiatic elephants have smaller ears than the African species, and a unique tip to their trunk (see opposite). The tusks are small and may be absent in females (above). The molar teeth are very like those of the extinct mammoth, which suggests a close relationship between them. The Asiatic elephant has a long association with humans, and animals from all 3 subspecies—Sumatran, Sri Lankan, and those from India and Malaysia—have been domesticated.